

CDN Incident Alert: 101. TLP: CLEAR		Date
Title	Coordinated Recruitment of Paid Diaspora Observers to Undermine Moldova	8/10/2025
	MD Election Integrity	

Summary

- A Facebook [ad campaign](#), consisting of 21 ads, directly recruited Moldovan diaspora citizens across Europe to act as “election observers” on 28 September (parliamentary election day). It offered 500 euro guaranteed + up to 30,000 euro in bonuses for each election irregularity identified, with payment in “cash the same day.” Recruitment and registration were done via WhatsApp, Telegram, and Viber, platforms that enable rapid, opaque mobilization.
- The ad did not mention any institutional affiliation (CEC, OSCE, ENEMO, Promo-LEX, etc.), making it inauthentic and misleading.
- The unusually high rewards create perverse incentives: people are motivated to “find” or even fabricate election irregularities, since payment is conditional on reporting alleged violations.
- Potential impact is inflated reports of fraud. By mobilizing diaspora “observers” with financial incentives, the operation can generate mass, unverified claims of electoral violations. These claims can later be amplified online to portray elections as illegitimate. Even if the claims are false, the appearance of diaspora observers reporting irregularities gives a veneer of credibility.
- Recommendations include urging Meta to remove inauthentic ads and pages; warning diaspora communities and embassies; alerting Moldovan electoral authorities and EU regulators to potential foreign interference; tasking CSIRTs to review teammoldova.md and share IoCs; monitoring linked entities (AdvertPro, HumanGo, PQ Hosting Plus S.R.L.) for repeat attempts; informing observer organizations (OSCE/ODIHR, Promo-LEX, CSOs) to safeguard credible missions; and preparing rapid debunk/triage mechanisms for viral election “irregularity” clips.

Incident

Between August 18 and September 25, 2025, the Polish-registered company [AdvertPro Digital Agency](#), owned by Ukrainian national Oleh Shmauts, ran a coordinated Facebook ad campaign via the page [HumanGo](#) (formerly Mold Service Poland → Lumen Personal → HumanGo). The campaign targeted Moldovan diaspora communities across Europe, recruiting them as “election observers” for the September 28 parliamentary elections with promises of a guaranteed 500 euro plus up to 30,000 euro in bonuses for reporting election “irregularities.” Ads in Romanian and Russian ran in France, Germany, Ireland, Italy, Portugal, Spain, Romania, and the UK.

Recruitment was funneled through multiple websites and messenger apps, including [aplicaacum.mssg.me](#), [taplink.cc/locurilimitate](#), and [28septembrie.mssg.me](#). These links redirected registrants to a UK phone number (+44) for WhatsApp/Telegram/Viber. Applicants were asked to provide full, personally identifiable information (PII), including copies of their IDs. They then received identical “observer/representative” manuals and were moved to WhatsApp/Telegram cohorts. This process created both privacy and security risks, as well as a potential database for future mobilization. Registrants were provided with detailed “observer mission” instructions, including schedules and task lists. After completing registration, they were contacted by phone from a Moldovan number (+373) and invited to online training sessions ahead of election day.

Registrants were instructed to select a political party (NOI, AUR, CUB, Andrei Năstase, or “doesn’t matter”). On September 27, one day before the elections, managers instructed that reports will be aggregated in 22 Telegram groups and mirrored to teammoldova.md and Excel sheets.

The operation relied on a structured chain of command, moving from local representatives up through regional coordinators and ultimately to a central operations center. Communication and tasking were handled through 22 primary Telegram groups, each backed up by a corresponding WhatsApp channel to ensure cross-border coordination and data consolidation.

Diaspora representatives were equipped with body-worn cameras and entry counters to document election activity. Financial records obtained by ZdG, a Moldovan investigative journalism outlet, show that the purchases for this equipment were [linked](#) to bank cards used by Gheorghe Zablodski, a Germany-based online propagandist with [ties](#) to Moldovan opposition journalist Natalia Morari, as well as to Valeri Zabolotnii, a person associated with the IFAVIS/[Karamalak](#) criminal figure.

Coordination on the ground extended into Romania, where former policeman Serghei Medic was [connected](#) to a hotel “[call centre](#)” in Iași. From there, calls were placed to Moldovan voters on behalf of Blocul „Patriotic.”

Ultimately, the entire flow of data and results was funnelled into the platform [teammoldova.md](#), hosted by [PQ Hosting Plus S.R.L.](#) This infrastructure is owned by two Moldovan citizens from the Transnistria region, Ivan and Iurie Neculiți, who are behind [EU-sanctioned Stark Industries Solutions](#), which for years has enabled Russian state-sponsored and affiliated actors to conduct destabilising activities—including information manipulation, interference, and cyber-attacks—against the EU and third countries.

Systemic Violation Assessment

The paid recruitment of diaspora “observers,” with financial rewards tied to reporting irregularities, introduces a systematic bias into election monitoring. Instead of ensuring impartial oversight, the scheme distorts the observation process by incentivizing fabrication or exaggeration of violations. This manufactured evidence can then be used to contest results and erode public confidence in the electoral outcome.

The incentive structure itself — a 300–500 euro base payment plus bonuses for each alleged election “irregularity” — virtually guarantees skewed reporting. It encourages participants to produce artificial documentation of electoral violations, reinforcing pre-set fraud narratives regardless of the actual conditions on the ground.

The operation uses a multi-stage recruitment funnel (Facebook ads → private messaging → Google Forms → training sessions) that masks its political nature as commercial employment opportunities. This constitutes non-transparent political advertising designed to circumvent platform policies and electoral transparency requirements.

The scheme potentially violates electoral law provisions against hindering electoral processes and corrupting election activities, as payments are conditioned on behaviors that could disrupt legitimate electoral procedures.

Additionally, this operation is breaching multiple layers of legal and regulatory frameworks. From a data protection perspective, the collection and storage of personal information — including copies of identity documents — constitutes unlawful processing under the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR). This exposure is heightened by the cross-border transfer of data without a lawful basis, leaving recruits vulnerable to misuse of their information and exposing organizers to significant sanctions.

Beyond civil or regulatory liability, elements of the operation may also fall under criminal law, particularly provisions related to false reporting, fraud, and offenses against public order, depending on the jurisdictions in which incidents occur.

The targeting of diaspora communities for political action in Moldova's election through EU-based operations raises questions about foreign interference regulations and campaign finance transparency requirements.

Narrative

Meta narrative: The Moldovan parliamentary elections are fraudulent and illegitimate.

Sub-narratives: Diaspora votes are being stolen; Massive fraud has been documented; Moldova is not a democracy.

Impact

Reach: Overall, the 21 ads reached more than 1,038,955 people, 895,694 across the EU and 143,261 in the UK;

Outcome: Unauthorized “observers” were spotted at Moldovan polling stations in Athens and Prague, remaining on-site from early morning until the close of voting. Their interactions with representatives of all four political parties cited in the registration forms confirmed suspicions of coordination. However, despite instructions uncovered by ZdG to film alleged irregularities, the observers failed to identify or document any suspicious activity.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective: [T0074.002: Domestic Political Advantage](#): recruit and deploy paid “observers” to generate and publicize alleged polling irregularities, creating pretexts to contest results and influence the domestic electoral outcome.

Objective: [T0135.003: Subvert](#): subverting the legitimate observation process by introducing paid actors with financial incentives to find problems.

[T0018: Purchase Targeted Advertisements](#): Meta ads aimed at Moldovan migrant communities solicit “observers” and drive them into the recruitment funnel.

[T0072.001: Geographic Segmentation](#): targeting by nationality/diaspora (Moldovan/Romanian) and known migrant hubs to maximise recruitment yield and localised impact.

[T0091.001: Recruit Contractors](#): cash-on-the-day offer (500 euro + “bonuses” per irregularity) used to sign up individuals via WhatsApp/Telegram/Viber.

[T0057.001: Pay for Physical Action](#) – direct cash payments contingent on in-person activity at polling stations and on reporting “irregularities”.

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Actions Taken: Monitoring conducted with Ziarul de Garda, WatchDog volunteers; assets mapped; evidence preserved (ads, manuals, chats, payment trails).

Recommendations:

- Urge Meta to investigate and remove associated ads and pages for coordinated inauthentic behavior.
- Notify Moldovan diaspora communities and embassies about the scam/interference attempt.
- Moldovan electoral authorities and EU regulators should flag the incident as potential foreign interference.
- Task CSIRTs to review teammoldova.md / PQ Hosting Plus S.R.L. for risk; share IoCs with EU partners;
- Track linked entities (AdvertPro, HumanGo, PQ Hosting Plus S.R.L.) for repeated attempts to set up the operation.
- Share findings with election observer organizations (OSCE/ODIHR, Promo-LEX, local CSOs) to protect the credibility of real monitoring missions.
- Prepare a rapid debunk/triage flow for viral election “irregularity” clips (context checks, chain-of-custody, provenance).

Report	Threat Actor	Evidence	Authors	Platforms	FIMI Assessment
N/A	Russia.	Upon Request	Victoria Olari DFRLab, Jakub Kubś, GLOBSEC, Digital Forensic Team	Facebook, Whatsapp, Telegram, Viber, hosting providers	High certainty